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sub-assemblies and all the seven major component assemblies will be done in India, along with tools, jigs and testers. Various systems such as engines, landing gear, avionics, EW suite etc. will be provided by Airbus Defence & Space and integrated into the aircraft. The aircraft will be tested as an integrated system by the TASL. The aircraft will be flight tested and delivered through a delivery centre at the facility

All 56 aircraft will be fitted with the indigenous electronic warfare suite of Bharat Electronics Ltd and Bharat Dynamics Limited

After the completion of the delivery of 56 aircraft to IAF, M/s Airbus Defence & Space will be allowed to sell aircraft manufactured in India to civil operators and export to countries cleared by the government

the private sector gets a much-needed push. It breaks the monopoly of HAL and brings competitiveness," he says.

Aviation experts note the increasingly robust role of the Indian private sector in defence manufacturing. For example, Tata Aerospace and Defence (Tata A&D) makes the fuselage of the AH-64 Apache combat helicopter, as well as the aero-structures for Boeing's CH-47 Chinook helicopters. Chopra adds that aero-structure components for the military transport aircraft C-130Js are produced in India and delivered to customers worldwide. Sikorsky, a Lockheed Martin company, also relies on Hyderabad-based TASL as the manufacturing base for its global supply of cabins for the S-92 helicopter. The Tata group is working with GE Aviation to manufacture CFM International LEAP engine components in India. Remarkably, Lockheed Martin selected TASL to produce F-16 fighter aircraft wings in India. "If our private sector makes critical parts for aircraft for the world, why should it not make an aircraft? It's high time to show confidence in private industries," asks Chopra.

Delays in the delivery of LCA Tejas are fresh in the minds of all. So, for producing the upcoming fifth-generation fighter aircraft—the Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (AMCA)—a special purpose vehicle (SPV) model with private partners is being worked on. An SPV is a legal entity/company set up to execute a project. In 2019, the ministry of defence formed a committee under former Defence Research and Development Organisation chairman and current NITI Aayog member V.K. Saraswat for working out an execution model for the AMCA. It was felt that the current pace of aircraft production needed to be increased by involving more players. The panel's report recommended an SPV to make the AMCA. Till now, the Aeronautical Development Agency (ADA), under the DRDO, designs an aircraft and HAL manufactures it. But, for the AMCA, an SPV may usher in a role for private industry. Once it gets cabinet approval, ADA will form the SPV. The sharing of tasks will be decided by the top leadership, but private players may be given a majority share in manufacturing. Actually, ADA has already initiated discussions with three top private companies to discuss a distribution of tasks regarding the AMCA.

INDIA'S PRIVATE SECTOR MAKES COMPONENTS FOR AIRCRAFT FIRMS WORLDWIDE. IT IS READY TO DO MORE

Air Marshal (retd) M. Matheswaran, former deputy chief of Integrated Defence Staff, says government policies over the years made HAL the sole maker of aircraft in India. He says the Tata-Airbus JV needs to look at export prospects for both civil and military aircraft, as the Indian military cannot give them large orders. "Tata will have to absorb technology and bring in value addition and develop. Most foreign companies do not allow its partner to do so. Airbus must be eyeing an increase in sales in the Indian market rather than taking an Indian industry into a global supply chain. Tata needs to break into the global supply chain—the Airbus market," says Matheswaran.

With a precedent set with the C-295, the government will hopefully let in more private players in the sector, foster a competitive spirit, and thus opt for more efficiency and rigour in aircraft manufacturing. The IAF will be grateful for it. ■